

Preparing for battle

Whatever their specifications and qualities, tanks are only as effective as the crews inside them. The work of the best engineers and designers, and the huge costs involved in manufacturing such complex machines, plus the testing and issuing of the equipment, is all wasted if the crew is unable to work the tank effectively. History has shown that experienced, motivated, and well-trained crews working technically inferior tanks have beaten superior vehicles crewed by less experienced or less motivated men. As in many other areas of warfare, the effect of motivation, morale, belief, and leadership, however hard to quantify, is of huge importance to a tank crew, and can have an enormous effect on their performance in battle.

American crewmen, for instance, in late 1944 or early 1945, could find themselves fighting against far superior German tanks—and winning. Later analysis revealed that at this stage of the war German tank crews were indeed insufficiently trained, and so suffered in spite of their own technical superiority. Studies also show that the stress of combat often led men to seek help, guidance, and comfort in religion. Statistics reveal that soldiers' reliance on prayer rose from 32 percent to 74 percent as the battle intensified.

US chaplain Major George F. Daum leads Sherman tank crews in prayer before their advance into Germany in 1945.

